

STP Workshop - Instructor Handout

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CHAPTER 6 WORKSHOP

Workshop: build STP for a real brand, then have an AI critic stress-test the position.

Workshop: build STP for a real brand, then have an AI critic stress-test the position.

By the end, every student has a written positioning statement, a five-criteria score on the target, and a perceptual map.

Open by setting expectations. This is the hands-on companion to the Chapter 6 lecture. Every student leaves with one written deliverable: a positioning statement for a brand they actually buy, defended against the chapter's machinery and stress-tested by an AI critic. The session is structured as six short activities: pick a brand and partner, name the segment, score it on the five criteria, write the position, build a perceptual map, run the AI critic. Tell students to open a chat assistant (Claude or ChatGPT) on a laptop or phone. They will use it in two of the six activities. The product of the session is a one-page document they can defend to a roommate.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- What brand are you going to work on today? Tell your neighbor and lock it in.

~75s spoken

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SETUP

Pick a real brand you buy, or one you would actually launch.

Pick a real brand you buy, or one you would actually launch.

Strong picks: Stanley, Liquid Death, the campus coffee shop, a tutoring service, an Etsy product you would sell.
Weak picks: a phone, a car.

Walk students through the brand-picking constraints. The brand has to be real or realistic enough that they can name a buyer segment and a next-best alternative. Strong picks are brands with one identifiable target: Stanley tumblers, Liquid Death, a campus coffee shop, a tutoring service, an Etsy product they would sell. Weak picks are anything where the buyer is everyone: a phone, a car, anything where the firm has multiple segments. Spend two minutes letting students pick and write the brand down. Pair them in twos. They will work alone for most activities but check in with their partner between each one. Tell them they can pick the same brand as their partner if both find it interesting.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- What is the next-best alternative your buyer would otherwise pick? Name it specifically.

~60s spoken

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ACTIVITY 1 / 6 MINUTES

Activity 1: Name your brand's target segment in one plain sentence.

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One sentence. Who is the buyer, and what do they actually want from the category. 6 minutes.

Walk the room through the activity steps before they start. Step one: write down the segment in one plain sentence. Felipe's working example is, women 25 to 44 who treat hydration as part of who they are. Step two: read it back. If the sentence has three clauses connected by ands, it is too broad. If it says people, it is too broad. If the sentence is one specific buyer doing one specific thing, it is right. Step three: trade your sentence with your partner. Each red-teams the other's sentence by asking, can you name three real people who fit this description and three who do not. If the answer is no, the segment is too vague. Six minutes total. Walk the room.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Can you name three people who fit your segment sentence, and three who do not?
- Is the sentence a real buyer doing a real thing, or marketing-deck words?

~60s spoken

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ACTIVITY 1 DEBRIEF

Debrief: pull three segment sentences and ask the room which one is winnable.

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Strongest sentence names a buyer the room can picture. Weakest sentence is broad enough to mean nobody specific.

Solicit three volunteers to read their segment sentences. For each, ask the rest of the room two questions. One: can you picture this buyer? Can you name a real person you know who fits? Two: is this the buyer you would chase, or just the easiest one to describe? Pull out the difference between a sentence that names a specific buyer and a sentence that names everyone with money. The strongest sentence usually has a specific occasion or value-orientation, not just a demographic. The weakest sentence is anyone aged 18 to 45 who likes coffee. That is not a segment. That is the everybody trap with a number range.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Which sentence reads as a real buyer? Which reads as a marketing deck?
- What single word would tighten the weakest sentence?

~75s spoken

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ACTIVITY 2 / 8 MINUTES

Activity 2: Score your segment against the five criteria, and find the one most likely to fail.

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Measurable, accessible, substantial, differentiable, actionable. Score 1 to 5 on each. The lowest score is where the work is. 8 minutes.

Walk students through the activity. Step one: write down each of the five criteria. Measurable, accessible, substantial, differentiable, actionable. Step two: rate your segment 1 to 5 on each. Step three: identify the lowest-scoring criterion. That is the test the segment is most likely to fail on, and that is where the strategic work is. Step four: write one sentence explaining why the lowest score is what it is. Step five: share with your partner. They check whether your scoring is honest or whether you over-rated to make the segment look usable. Tell students the most common failure on student projects is actionable. The team identifies a great segment that they themselves cannot serve with the resources they have. That is research, not a target.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Which criterion is your lowest score? What would have to change for that score to rise?
- Did you give yourself a high score where the answer is honestly unclear?

~70s spoken

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ACTIVITY 2 CAVEAT

Common pitfall: actionable is the criterion teams over-rate to make the segment look usable.

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Identifying a perfect segment the firm cannot afford to serve is not a strategy. It is research.

Pause to call out the trap. Actionable asks whether the firm has the resources to actually run a program for the segment. Students systematically over-rate this on their own projects because the segment they identified is exciting and they want to believe they can serve it. Tell them honesty here is part of the discipline. A small firm that identifies a global luxury segment may lack distribution, budget, and retail presence to act on it. That segment is not a target. It is research. The cure is to either pick a smaller segment the firm can actually serve, or to be clear that the firm needs to acquire resources before this segment is real. Either is fine. What is not fine is calling it a target while everyone in the room knows the firm cannot afford it.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- What would your firm need to acquire to make your lowest-scoring criterion an honest 5?

~50s spoken

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ACTIVITY 3 / 8 MINUTES

Activity 3: Write your positioning statement in the four-clause template, then audit each clause.

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For target who need, brand is the category that biggest difference because reason to believe. 8 minutes.

Walk students through the activity. Step one: write the statement in the template. For target who need, brand is the category that biggest difference because reason to believe. Step two: audit each clause. Target: one plain sentence, the one you wrote in activity one. Need: something a buyer would name unprompted, not a marketing word. Category: who you actually compete against. Difference: passes desirable, deliverable, differentiating. Reason to believe: the clause a rival cannot say word for word. Step three: cross out any clause a rival could say word for word. That is the test that catches lazy writing. Step four: trade with your partner. They red-team the RTB clause specifically. Most weak statements are weak because the RTB is something every brand in the category could claim.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Could your closest rival say your RTB clause word for word? If yes, rewrite it.
- Does your difference clause pass all three POD tests?

~75s spoken

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ACTIVITY 3 DEBRIEF

Debrief: read three positioning statements and ask the room which RTB clause is the strongest.

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Strongest RTB is something the firm can prove and a rival cannot match on a normal product-development calendar.

Solicit three volunteers to read their full positioning statements aloud. For each, ask the room to grade the RTB clause specifically. Is it something the firm can prove. Is it something a rival could match by next quarter. The strongest RTBs rest on a real head start, hard engineering, an audited share lead, a heritage the calendar cannot fake, or a true specialty. Patagonia's one percent since 1985 is the textbook example because no rival can backdate forty years of compounded giving. The weakest RTBs are bare claims of quality, customer focus, or low price. Any rival could and probably does say the same thing. Tell students this is the clause brand teams most often skip past, and it is the one that decides whether the position holds.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Which RTB do you believe? Why that one?
- Which one could a rival copy by next quarter?

~80s spoken

ACTIVITY 4 / 10 MINUTES

Activity 4: Build a perceptual map for your brand and three rivals, then test the empty quadrant.

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Pick two axes the buyer cares about. Plot four dots. Find the empty corner. Ask whether buyer ideal points actually live there. 10 minutes.

Walk students through the activity. Step one: pick the two attributes the buyer actually cares about, from the laddering work in chapter five if they have done that, or from common sense if not. Tell them to write the attributes on the axes. Step two: plot your brand and three rivals as dots. Be honest about where the buyer would put each, not where the firm wishes the buyer would put it. Step three: look at the empty quadrant. Is it empty because no brand has gone there, or because there is no buyer demand there? Step four: write one sentence answering that question. Sketch a buyer ideal-point cluster anywhere on the map and ask whether it overlaps the empty corner. If yes, the empty quadrant is an opening. If no, it is dead air the incumbents already priced in. Ten minutes total.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Where do the buyer ideal points actually cluster on your map?
- Is the empty corner an opening or dead air? Defend your answer in one sentence.

~90s spoken

ACTIVITY 4 CAVEAT

Common pitfall: declaring the axes in the boardroom instead of recovering them from buyer ratings.

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If buyers sort the category on different attributes than the ones you drew, the map predicts choices badly. A real PCA on rating data costs a few hundred dollars in 2026.

Tell students the most common failure on a perceptual map is declaring the axes from the brief. The team writes premium versus value because that is what the firm thinks about. The buyer is actually sorting the category on individualistic-versus-communal and playful-versus-serious. A premium-versus-value map will predict purchase choices badly. The 2026 fix is cheap. Factor analysis on a 20-attribute buyer rating survey, fielded to 200 respondents through a panel like Prolific or Cint, runs a few hundred dollars and a couple of days. The output is the two attributes that explain the most variance in how buyers see the category. Use those, not the ones you guessed at first.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- What would the data probably surface for your category that you would not have guessed?

~60s spoken (skip if short)

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ACTIVITY 5 / 10 MINUTES

Activity 5: Run the AI critic on your positioning, sharp prompt first.

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One prompt with the four clauses, three rivals, and the explicit ask to flag any clause a rival could match. 10 minutes.

Open a chat assistant. Make sure web search is on, so the model can look up current rivals and pricing. The sharp prompt is on the next slide. Walk students through the activity. Step one: paste the sharp prompt with your positioning statement, three named rivals, and the explicit ask to score each clause. Step two: read the response. Note which clauses the model flags as weak, and which it confirms. Step three: paste the vague version of the same ask: is this positioning any good? Step four: compare the two responses. The point of the activity is that the sharp prompt returns a defensible audit tied to named tests, while the vague prompt returns generic advice. The same assistant at the same cost, two different answers, depending entirely on how you asked.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Which clauses did the model flag? Did it catch anything you missed?
- What is the gap between the sharp and vague responses, in your own words?

~75s spoken

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ACTIVITY 5 PROMPT

The sharp prompt: audit each clause against the three POD tests, name three rivals, flag any clause the rival could say.

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Audit my positioning for [brand]. The target is [X], the need is [Y], the difference is [Z], the RTB is [W]. Three named rivals: [A, B, C]. Score each clause.

Read the sharp prompt aloud once, slowly. The sharp prompt has four components: the audit ask, the four clauses of the positioning statement, the three named rivals, and the explicit instruction to score each clause against the three POD tests. Tell students to also instruct the model to search the web for the rivals' current positioning so the comparison is current, not from training data. The lazy version, is this positioning any good, returns advice they could have guessed. The sharp version returns a clause-by-clause audit tied to specific tests. The gap between those two responses, at the same cost in cents, is most of the lesson. The principle generalizes: the question controls the answer more than the model does.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Write your prompt in a notes app first. Read it back. Is it sharp enough?

~50s spoken

ACTIVITY 5 DEBRIEF

Debrief: what did the model get right, and what would you still verify?

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Almost always right: naming weak clauses, surfacing rivals' current claims. Always verify: specific rival prices, share figures, anything where the training cutoff matters.

Pull two or three volunteers to share what the model returned. For each, ask two questions. What did the model get right. Almost always: naming weak clauses, surfacing the rivals' current positioning, suggesting a tighter RTB. What would you not trust. Usually: specific competitor prices that may be stale, share-of-market figures from training data, anything where the model could not have actually checked. The 2026 fix is that web search returns current numbers, but you still verify them on the rival's actual site before you act. Treat the model's read as a first pass, not a finished audit. The strongest student instinct here is to trust the model where it makes you feel good and discount it where it does not. Resist that.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Did the model name a weak clause you would not have caught yourself?
- What single fact from the response would you double-check before relying on it?

~65s spoken

ACTIVITY 6 / 6 MINUTES

Activity 6: Run your target through the ethics check before you call it done.

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Does the cut reconstruct a protected trait? Could the audience include children? Would the buyer feel watched? 6 minutes.

Walk the ethics check from the lecture. Three questions. One: does the cut reconstruct a protected trait? If your descriptors, combined, let you guess someone's health, pregnancy, religion, or race, you are targeting on that trait even if you never named it. Each variable being lawful does not make the combination lawful. Two: could the audience include children? If minors can fall inside the segment, COPPA and platform rules apply, and a cut that was fine for adults is now a separate legal question. Three: would the buyer feel watched if you told them how you found them? If explaining the targeting out loud would read as creepy or as price discrimination, that is the Orbitz problem, and the reputational cost lands whether or not the law does. Take six minutes. Apply the three questions to your own brand's target.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Does your target fail any of the three questions? Which one is hardest to satisfy?
- If you were a regulator, would you investigate your own brand?

~70s spoken

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DELIVERABLE

Final 6 minutes: write your one-page positioning brief.

Final 6 minutes: write your one-page positioning brief.

Brand, segment, five-criteria score, positioning statement, map sketch, AI audit verdict, ethics check. One page.

The deliverable is one page. Tell students to write or type it now while everything is fresh. The structure is seven blocks. One: brand and segment in one sentence. Two: five-criteria score with the lowest-scoring criterion called out. Three: positioning statement in the four-clause template. Four: a sketch of the perceptual map with brand, three rivals, and the empty-quadrant verdict. Five: the AI audit verdict, listing which clauses the model flagged and which it confirmed. Six: ethics check, noting which of the three questions, if any, is risky. Seven: the position you would actually ship, with a one-sentence defense. This document is the artifact of the session. It is also a template they can run on any other brand after the class.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- What is the one sentence you would say to your CMO to defend this positioning?

~50s spoken

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CROSS-REVIEW

Share: trade one-pagers with your partner and red-team each other.

Share: trade one-pagers with your partner and red-team each other.

Find the weakest clause in the positioning statement. Find the rival the AI audit missed. 5 minutes total.

Pair students up and have them swap one-pagers. Each partner is the red team. They look for two specific weaknesses. The weakest clause in the positioning statement, the one with the softest claim. And the rival the AI audit missed, where the model could have named a category competitor and did not. Five minutes each direction. The point is that partnerships catch what solo work misses. Tell students this is what brand teams at real firms do at weekly reviews. The work is not done when one person finishes it. It is done when two people sign off.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- Which clause in your partner's positioning needs the most defense?
- What rival did your partner's AI audit miss?

~50s spoken

CLOSE

You have a defensible positioning now, with the segment named, the clauses audited, and the map tested.

You have a defensible positioning now, with the segment named, the clauses audited, and the map tested.

Take the one-pager home. Run the same procedure on the next brand you buy.

Close the session by reminding students what they did. They named a segment in one plain sentence, scored it on the five criteria, wrote a positioning statement in the four-clause template, built a perceptual map, ran a sharp AI audit on the statement, and applied the ethics check. That is the full STP decision a brand team runs at a real firm. Tell them the one-pager is theirs to keep. The next time they buy something they should run this same procedure on the brand selling to them. They will spot the segment the brand is targeting. They will read the positioning off the page. They will know which clause is doing the work and which one is weak. That habit is most of what separates a chapter six reader from a positioning professional.

DISCUSSION PROMPTS.

- What is the next brand you will run this on, after you leave the room?

~60s spoken
